before the light fades

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before the light fades

by tonestorm

Summary

> “You’d tell me if something was wrong, right?” *Just tell me.*
>
> “I… yes? Of course. But nothing is wrong. Sweetheart, are you sure you’re alright?” Phainon asked, a touch of concern in his voice.
>
> *I saw you with her today. At the café. You lied to me; said you were at the office. You’ve been lying to me for a very long time, haven’t you, Phainon?*

or Mydei gets his heart broken on a random sunny day in October.

Notes

> used to be a meta player and now im writing fics about phainon drinking mydei's pussy juice. lord help me.

See the end of the work for more notes

It happened on a random day in October. Mydei still remembered that the weather that day was unusually warm – the wind was refreshing instead of bitingly cold, the birds were softly chirping and the trees were still clad in their golden glory, not yet naked to the human eye.

The day was perfect. It was warm, sunny – the ideal time to go out and spend time with your friends and loved ones, to enjoy your time together.

It was on a day like this that Mydei's heart was irrevocably broken.

*

Mydei wondered what was the point of no return.

How had he never noticed it.

It didn't start with a big fight. Now that he looked back, he realized the warning signs have always been there – flashing red, trying, *begging* to be noticed. Impossible to miss, really.

Too bad Mydei was so busy being in love that all the warning signs went straight over his head.

The day that started this spiral began just like any other – Mydei woke up to an empty bed and with a bright sticky note on the bedside table.

"Went to work :(Already fed the beast. Don't wait up for me!"

He smiled, carefully folding the note. He knew how much Phainon has been working, how busy their law firm has been for the past few months, trying so hard to secure the deal with Penacony. He didn't think much of it before sending a text to his boyfriend.

"Going on a walk with Castorice. The dinner will be in the fridge.

Good luck. Love you."

He hadn't even put down the phone when he already got multiple responses from Phainon, as if he'd been waiting for him to wake up.

He stood up from their bed and stretched for a bit – all this workload at the bakery has been making him rusty; he really needed to find some time to hit up the gym. Perhaps he will even drag Phainon there once he was done with his current project at work.

Making his way to their kitchen, he quickly prepared breakfast. Sitting alone at the dining table, he absentmindedly stared out the window. The window in their kitchen was slightly open, making his hair flutter in the air – he carelessly tied it up, and took a bite of his food.

The savory breakfast burst with flavor in his mouth, making him let out an unconscious hum as he indulged himself with a smile.

It really was a good day. If only Phainon wasn't called out to work it would have been absolutely perfect.

He quietly washed the dishes when something soft and furry brushed against his bare legs. He heard an indignant *meow* coming from somewhere below and looked down with a raised eyebrow.

"Hello. I've been told you've been already fed." He bent down a little to pet the big orange cat. Nikador has been a fairly new addition to their house – he used to be a street cat, one that loved to spend his time around Mydei's bakery. Apparently, that was his 'territory' before Mydei dared to encroach on it.

The bakery was supposed to be a somewhat side-business for Mydei, a little hobby, or a pet project, as some called it. As a beloved heir to a multibillion company *Kremnos*, Mydei had no reason to work a day in his life. His parents were still young and knew Mydei didn't want to take any part in the family business. Eurypon and Gorgo, though strict, loved him a lot – they let him do whatever he wanted and supported him in everything. Their only requirement was for him to know the basics, so if it was ever needed, he could take control of the company and have his finger on its pulse. Mydei easily agreed. He finished business school, got a degree, made a deal with Krateros and his friends that worked at the company that they would regularly give him updates on the family business and only then he opened his bakery – his little place of haven.

It wasn't a big place – it was strategically placed in the little alley in the middle of the city, hidden unless you looked for it. The first time he saw it he instantly fell in love. He could've already imagined how he would decorate it, where he'd put the tables, what kind of music he'd play and what kind of menu he'd prepare that would be worthy of this place. It was love at first sight.

Mydei fought tooth and nail for that place, went through one struggle after another – the place had incredible charm but it was old and, as it always happened with old places, it came with its own set of problems. Electricity, heating, constant flooding and never-ending renovations – it took a few years before Mydei officially opened his bakery.

But it happened on his terms, with his close friends and family behind him. It was the happiest day in his life.

And this was also the place where he met Phainon again. He was one of the first customers that visited his bakery, one that became a regular as soon as he tasted Mydei's special golden honeycakes. It was too, love at first sight for him.

Or love at first taste, Mydei thought with amusement.

A slightly shrill *meow* pulled him from his memories. Mydei blinked and lightly flicked Nikador's fluffy head.

“No more food for you. Look at how big you’ve become. If it continues this way I’ll have to buy a leash and bring you on my morning runs,” he threatened. Nikador bristled as soon as he heard the cursed phrase – ‘morning runs’. Mydei only saw an orange flash before the cat disappeared around the corner. For such a lazy creature he sure ran fast when needed.

The king of the streets. More like a lazy, always hungry menace.

He grabbed his phone and shot a quick text to Castorice, letting her know that he’ll be at their place in 20 minutes. Seeing her response, he put his phone down and got ready. There was something he wanted to grab from his bakery, so he had to hurry.

*

By the time Mydei and Castorice met up the park was unsurprisingly full of people. The summer sun and its blistering heat had finally faded into the autumn afternoons, washing the people basking in sunlight with its gentle warmth. It took some time before they found a quiet corner right under a big tree, shaded from everyone’s prying eyes.

Mydei and Castorice met through Phainon, during one of the corporate events they had at the law firm. Something involving team-building, if Mydei remembered correctly. It was the first time Phainon had officially took him as his plus one, introducing him to everyone as his boyfriend. Mydei remembered how worried he was before the event – he never cared what others thought of him but still, he wanted to make a good impression as Phainon’s partner. He knew Phainon had also never taken anyone as his date to any event, always preferring to go alone and brush off everyone’s questions about when he was going to bring someone to show off. It was the first time for both of them and Mydei wanted it to be perfect.

The introduction went without a hitch – surprisingly, the boss Phainon had talked so much about was a dear friend of Mydei’s mother, one that knew him since he was very young.

“So, you are the man that has our dear Phainon wrapped around his finger,” she laughed when she finally saw him, her gold eyes sparkling with humor.

A blush brightened his features. No matter how much he tried he couldn’t hide the warmth that flooded his cheeks. Still, he returned her embrace with a smile.

“It’s been a long time. it’s nice to see you again, Aglaea.”

It was on that event where he met Castorice, a plus one of Phainon’s colleague, Cipher. She was standing on the balcony, breathing in the fresh air and enjoying the soft night when Mydei joined her in her solitude. The night was beautiful and with quiet smiles an unlikely friendship had sparked.

It’s been a long time since then – in the meantime Castorice had married her long-term girlfriend Cipher and Mydei had finally moved in with Phainon, their relationship growing stronger by the day.

Breathing in the scent of fresh leaves, Mydei leaned on the tree behind him with a sigh. He passed the bundle of freshly baked cookies to Castorice – he was trying a new recipe and had some leftovers. He thought she'd like the savory taste this batch had thanks to the miso paste he added on Phainon's suggestion. He tried one before giving them to her, they were pretty good. Sprinkled with some flaky salt and they were ready to be served to their customers. Perhaps he would add them to their menu later.

And based on Castorice's happy little dance she liked them well enough.

"Thank you," she popped another cookie into her mouth. "Delicious as always."

The sun softly caressed their faces, as if giving them a gentle kiss. Mydei smiled at his friend and quickly shot a picture of their picnic blanket for Phainon. He knew his boyfriend was probably dying under assignments, so he made sure to attach a picture of leftover cookies with a note.

"There are some for you at home. It's the ones with miso; you seemed to like them. Come home sooner."

His lips quirked up at Phainon's immediate response. No matter the constant cold war between Nikador and Phainon, they were truly too similar in some aspects. He quickly pocketed his phone and raised his head, accidentally meeting Castroice's eyes.

"Phainon," he explained, waving his hand carelessly. "He's stuck in the office, working on their big project. I'm sure you know – I think Cipher is involved too."

The sun had slowly dipped behind the clouds, taking with it the warmth that kissed their faces just a moment ago. Mydei swiftly took a fluffy blanket from his bag and covered himself and Castorice with it. The weather was unpredictable; he didn't want any of them to get sick.

Hearing no response, Mydei looked at her and noticed her curious if slightly confused smile.

He didn't know at the time that the next words she said would destroy the illusion that was his happy relationship.

(It started here.)

"The one with Penacony?" seeing his nod, she tucked a strand of lavender hair behind her ear before continuing without a thought. "But didn't they finish it almost a month ago? I think Cipher even took some days off to emotionally recover after they were finally done."

She smiled at him as if they were sharing an inner joke. And of course, why wouldn't she think that – she's been with Cipher for so long, she more than anyone in Mydei's life knew what it was like being married to a successful lawyer. Late nights and constant business trips were the least of their worries.

Too bad that this time Mydei had no idea what she was talking about.

He shook his head with a frown. “No, they didn’t. Phainon has been stuck in the office all this time because he was working on it. He would have told me if they were done.”

And he would have, Mydei knows that – they met when Phainon was just starting to work at the company, Mydei was there with him from the very beginning of his journey, celebrating all his wins like they were his own. And with this project in particular – Mydei had sat with Phainon until three in the morning, helping him with the documents, listening and correcting his speech, so that everyone would be satisfied with his delivery. He saw how stressed Phainon was and tried to help as much as he could – there was no way Phainon wouldn’t have told him that the deal went through. It just wasn’t possible.

Castorice fidgeted a little with her phone, scrolling for a bit, before turning the screen to him and showing him a picture of her and Cipher in their apartment.

Mydei visited them a few times, he recognized their home immediately. The Cipher in the photo was buried in Castorice embrace, one tired cyan eye peeking from under her arm. She was clearly relaxing at home when her wife took the picture – the bags under her eyes and the dark red shirt she stole from Mydei during one of their trips was a dead giveaway.

“That was taken the next day after they finally closed the deal.” Castorice shuffled to his side, so that she also could look at the photo. She smiled softly, “She doesn’t like to admit it, but Cipher really needed some peace and quiet after it. It took a lot from her, both physically and emotionally.” She swiped to show another picture, this time with Cipher sleeping under a blanket with their cat in her arms. “I thought she’d want go out to celebrate the closing of the deal but she was so dead on her feet, that we stayed home the whole weekend.”

Mydei looked at the date of the photo – a month ago. The photos were taken a month ago, just as Castorice said.

He knew there was no reason for her to lie. Yet he couldn’t understand for what reason *Phainon* would lie to him.

Mydei tried to remember what they did on the day the deal was supposedly done. It’s been some time ago but he still remembered that was one of the rare days Phainon had come home early.

He remembered it was a regular day at the bakery. Nothing memorable happened that day and he left the keys to Hyacine, trusting her to get everything in order and close on time. He had some documents to take care of at home – Hephaestion texted him that morning, telling him the monthly report was sent today and he should look at it when he had the chance, the team wanted to know his opinion on some topics mentioned there.

He came home, fed Nikador and took a shower – his usual routine. After preparing himself some food he quickly looked through reports Hephaestion mentioned. It was around that time that Phainon sent him a text, telling him that Aglaea let them off early today, so he’ll be home soon.

They clearly had different interpretations of what ‘soon’ meant because in the time it took Phainon to get to their apartment, Mydei prepared dinner, cleaned the apartment and even

took a small nap. It was during that brief moment of rest that he heard the door open. Nikador grumbled somewhere around his neck before he stood up and went to greet his 'father'. Mydei was usually a very heavy sleeper but since Phainon had texted him earlier he wanted to wait for him – it's been so long since they properly spent time together, he didn't want to miss even a second of it.

Mydei felt the bed dip and groggily opened his eyes. "Hey," he smiled softly, reaching a hand towards him. "Welcome home."

Phainon, eyes bright, took his hand and gently kissed the back of it. "It's good to be home. Did I wake you?"

"No, it's fine," he murmured before trying to sit up. "How was your day?" He gave Phainon a light pat on his cheek and then rubbed his eyes with a yawn.

"It was," Phainon stood up and took off his jacket. He slightly stumbled over his words. "Good. We made big progress today."

Mydei raised his head. "Oh? A celebration is in order?"

Phainon laughed. He was wearing his favorite dark blue suit today, the one that made a striking contrast with his light hair and made his brilliant blue eyes shine even more. He lost his dark tie somewhere and the first three buttons of his shirt were already unbuttoned, showing a glimpse of his well-defined chest. Slightly more awake now, Mydei raised an eyebrow at his state.

"What happened?"

Phainon waved off his questions. "it's nothing, don't worry about it. Now about that celebration…" He shrugged off his shirt and grabbed Mydei's legs, dragging him to the edge of the bed. Slotting himself between his thighs, Phainon firmly pressed his hand on Mydei's neck forcing him to raise his head. Caged in like this, Mydei could only stare wide-eyed at his boyfriend, fully awake this time.

Phainon caressed his face with his other hand and smiled down at him. "I have some ideas in mind."

There was not much talking done after that.

"Mydei?" Castorice worried voice drew him back from his memories. He looked at her with a start. "Hasn't Phainon… mentioned anything?"

He shook his head.

No, he hasn't. And now that Mydei thought about it, Phainon hasn't mentioned any actual details about the deal in some time. Even when Mydei asked, he hadn't said anything, instead trying to divert his attention to something else.

A month. He hasn't mentioned anything in a month, a disoriented voice in the back of his head whispered. *But why?*

Castorice seemed a little taken aback. After all, she also knew Phainon. She knew how unusual this was.

The wind picked up, tugging at their clothes. The sun was still hiding behind the clouds.

She glanced down at the phone loosely held in Mydei's hand, and gently touched his shoulder.

"Maybe, I'm wrong. Perhaps there was some additional details that needed Phainon's attention or," she said encouragingly, "maybe I really am talking about a different project. You know how it is – they have such massive workload, it's impossible to keep up."

She really was too good to him, Mydei smiled, golden eyes staring fixatedly at their picnic blanket. But it was too late now – the floodgates have already been opened. The first seed of doubt has been planted.

Observant as always, Castorice noticed his muddled state, her delicate eyebrows furrowing a bit. "I'm sorry for making you uncomfortable." She said, her voice uncharacteristically quiet. Purple eyes shone in guilt, as if it was her fault that Mydei's boyfriend has been possibly lying to him for weeks.

Mydei's mind was a blur of images, trying and failing to make sense of anything. The late nights, the constant excuses… Even today Phainon had used the Penacony deal to get out of spending their morning together. Surely, there must be a reason?

"No," he forced another smile to his face. *It's not Castorice's fault,* he repeated. *There has to be a reason.* "I will talk to him. Thank you for telling me," the smile Mydei sent her this time was small but genuine. "You're a good friend, Castorice."

The sun has finally peeked out from the clouds, flooding him with warmth he couldn't feel.

*

They had to part ways soon after that conversation – Cipher was waiting for Castorice at home and Mydei… There was only an empty apartment to welcome him. And his fat cat Nikador, of course.

When Mydei finally closed the door to his and Phainon's apartment, Castorice's last words still lingered in his head.

Her light touch stopped him in his tracks. Mydei turned to look at her, immediately meeting her sad smile.

"I feel like this is somehow my fault," seeing him open his mouth ready to refute her, she quickly shook her head. "No, please, listen to me. I've known Phainon for more than five years. This has to be some kind of misunderstanding."

“Please. Talk to him before making up your mind.”

He appreciated the reminder but there was no need for it – he planned on talking first anyway. He didn’t like doubting his boyfriend, in all years they’ve been together Phainon has never given him a reason to do so. He was the perfect partner, the most considerate and loving man he’s ever known.

Once he’s gotten out of his head, he realized how unreasonably he’s been acting. That must have been what prompted Castorice to tell him not to jump to any conclusions.

Mydei roughly ran his hand through his hair. Phainon was the love of his life. Of course, he was going to talk to him first.

He nimbly sidestepped Nikador’s attack of the day and made his way to the kitchen. That reminded him – the beast was out for blood. It was time to feed it.

Everything else could wait.

*

Mydei really tried to wait for Phainon to come home so that they could have a talk. He didn’t want to wait – he felt like the longer he waited, the worse it could become. He was always the kind of person that went straight to the root of the problem, trying to solve it as quickly as possible. He was never one to dawdle. But… the bed was right there. And he was dead on his feet.

He didn’t hear when Phainon came in. His first clue that something might have changed from the usual routine of the past month was a familiar naked chest pressing against his back.

Slightly more awake now, he felt strong arms circle his waist, drawing him closer and closer until there was no space between their bodies.

“Shhh, go to sleep. I’ve got you,” Phainon whispered, placing a hot kiss on the side of his neck.

Half asleep, Mydei turned his head but before he could even open his mouth, Phainon was quick to claim his lips in a deep kiss. Tasting the slightly bitter taste of alcohol on Phainon’s tongue, Mydei furrowed his brows but still unconsciously relaxed in his hold, becoming boneless in less than a second. He felt Phainon’s hand take its usual place – under his shirt, softly fondling his chest, rolling one perked nipple between his fingers – and he couldn’t help but relax even further.

He was asleep before he knew it, not even feeling the kiss Phainon left on his nape.

*

The next day Mydei once again woke up to an empty bed, but this time Phainon's side wasn't ice cold – instead it was slightly warm, still retaining some of the heat from his body. Hearing a mocking tune coming from the kitchen, he knew Phainon was home – his boyfriend only ever sang that song when he was making fun of their cat.

An angry hiss coming a second later only confirmed his thoughts. Mydei smiled into his pillow before turning his head and looking at Phainon's side of the bed. Seeing rumpled sheets, he quickly looked around and shuffled slightly before laying his head on his boyfriend's pillow. Breathing in deep, he felt satisfaction curl in his chest – Phainon was still wearing the cologne he bought him a few years ago.

As Mydei buried deeper into Phainon's pillow, he could feel his chest tighten from affection, his cheeks hurting from how hard he was smiling.

Phainon is home.

The effect he had on Mydei was truly embarrassing sometimes.

The second he let his thoughts wander he heard the door of the bedroom open. Phainon stuck his head inside and seeing him awake, he beamed at him with his signature radiant smile.

"You're up!" Mydei noticed that he was wearing Mydei's own pink apron, the one Cipher got him in exchange for the red shirt she stole. He remembered how hard she laughed when she saw him actually wear it but the apron was useful and Mydei has never been one to waste clothes, so the apron stayed. Cipher eventually realized that he actually quite liked the, admittedly, very ugly thing and bought him more things from the set. Mydei really should have expected that Phainon, notoriously known for his bad taste, would also grow fond of it.

"Wait here, don't get up!" Phainon quickly ran to the kitchen and came back with a tray filled to the brim with Mydei's favorite breakfast food – there was a plate of honeycakes topped with syrup and fresh pomegranate seeds, Phainon's signature light salad, some fresh fruit tarts from Mydei's own bakery and even a variety of drinks.

Mydei looked at everything and couldn't help but raise his eyebrows in surprise. "What's all this for? What's the occasion?"

Phainon cut a piece of the homemade golden honeycakes and offered it to Mydei. Only when Mydei opened his mouth, he responded with a smile, "Do I need a special occasion to spoil you?"

Still chewing, Mydei shot him a skeptical look.

It wasn't that unusual for Phainon to make breakfast in bed. For Phainon from a month ago, that is. Current Phainon was always so busy with work – it was considered a good day if Mydei managed to catch a glimpse of him these days, nevermind breakfast in bed.

That actually reminded him of the conversation he had with Castorice yesterday.

Mydei took a second to look at his boyfriend. He looked just as usual – all happy smiles and bright eyes. Even the ugly pink apron didn't ruin his look, instead adding a special charm only Phainon could pull off.

He looked like Phainon. The Phainon Mydei fell in love with years ago. The one he wanted to spend the rest of his life with.

Not wanting to beat around the bush, Mydei changed the topic, "I met Castorice yesterday."

"Yeah? How is she, by the way?"

Mydei took another bite of the offered honeycakes. "Fine. She and Cipher bought a new car. The model is pretty good, especially for those with kids."

He saw Phainon mouth drop in awe. "Kids? They're planning for kids?"

"They are," Mydei smiled imagining the picture-perfect couple. That image, more than anything, prompted him to finally say what's been bothering him since last night. He needed to know.

Mydei tried to be casual about it at first. "Castorice also mentioned that the Penacony deal went through. That the deal has been done for more than a month, in fact. Is that true?"

He saw Phainon freeze.

"Phainon?" *Calm down.*

Phainon jerked his head and laughed sheepishly. "I must have forgotten to tell you. Yes, the deal went through, we got everything finalized a few weeks ago. It's not yet put into practice but the groundwork is already there and that's what matters, if you ask me."

Something inside of Mydei wilted.

That was a lie. His smile always twitches at the corners when he lies. Mydei knows him better than anyone.

Phainon is lying to him.

Mydei quickly pushed the feeling down. He still needed answers because that was not the thing that made him worried. It was fine if Phainon forgot to tell him about the successful closing of the most important deal in his career, really, Mydei knew how much he worked and how many cases he had to deal with daily – it was a given that something might fall through or get forgotten in the process.

No, that was the least of his worries. If Phainon had really forgot to tell him then Mydei would have just thrown a late celebration for him at home and stopped thinking about the whole thing. He wasn't unreasonable after all.

It was more so the fact that Phainon still used that deal to get out of spending his time with Mydei. Even yesterday, the Penacony deal was his excuse.

Mydei remembered the many texts telling him how Phainon was going to be late, that Aglaea had asked them to stay in the office, that someone on their team sent the wrong draft to the clients and now Phainon had to stay and work overtime to fix everything… It was one thing after another. At first Mydei remembered being worried because even at the peak of it the Penacony team hadn't caused so many problems but when he brought his concerns to Phainon he was quick to reassure him.

"It's okay. It should pass soon enough."

"Don't worry, they're just trying to squeeze as much from us as possible. Since we're not giving in, we're kind of stuck in this headlock for now."

"This is normal. Expected, really."

After hearing the same thing over and over again, Mydei stopped asking and took Phainon at his word – why wouldn't he? Phainon has never lied to him. At least, not when it came to this.

That was before he talked to Castorice.

Now Mydei wasn't so sure.

Still, he tried again. "Just yesterday, you said…"

Suddenly Phainon interrupted him, slightly jolting forward as if he expected Mydei to bring this up. "Oh," his expression was sweet, a little sheepish as he rubbed the back of his head. "That's a different contract, my dear Mydeimos. Since our original deal was so successful, Penacony decided they wanted us on more of their projects."

He's still going with it? "Really."

"What, you don't believe me? Ask anyone, they'd tell you the same thing!"

He tried to act natural, as if he was unbothered and maybe, if Mydei didn't know him so well, he would've believed him. Unfortunately for Phainon, Mydei knew him. Perhaps even too well.

What he had trouble detecting before became crystal clear now.

"Phainon. Are you sure there isn't anything you want to tell me?" *Last chance.*

"Yeah. Why?" Big blue eyes blinked at him in confusion.

Breathe out. "No reason. Thank you for the breakfast. It was delicious."

Anyone, huh? Alright.

Seeing as Phainon was adamant on continuing the lie, it appeared that Mydei had to try another angle.

As soon as Phainon left the room taking the tray of food with him, Mydei unplugged his phone from the charger and opened his chat with Cipher. She may be Phainon's colleague but he was much closer to her. Their friendship came first.

There was no need for empty pleasantries between them.

Mydei
Hey. Does your company have any more dealings with the Penacony Co.?

Cipher
Well hello, little lion!

I'm fine, thank you for asking!

Mydei
I met Castorice just yesterday. I know you're fine.

I assume congratulations are in order?

Cipher
Awww, you're so kind

I'll be expecting a whole feast; no slacking allowed!

Mydei
You got it. I'll start preparing the menu for you next week.

Cipher
You're so cute

But to answer your question – no, we don't. That deal last month was the extent of our partnership.

Mydei
Are you certain?

Cipher
Of course

I'm the point of contact for everything related to Penacony. They can't do anything without going through me first

There are no more deals. At least, not ones related to Penacony.

*

Mydei slowly turned off his phone. There, he had it now.

Undeniable proof that Phainon was hiding something from him.

But it didn't have to be bad, right? Maybe he's just preparing a surprise. Maybe Cipher and Castorice just don't know about it.

It was Phainon, Mydei knew he'd never hurt him. This had to be it.

Mydei sat at the edge of their bed, trying and failing to ignore the slight bitterness that has already settled in the back of his throat. The questions floating in his head.

He knew there was no way he was getting an answer out of Phainon – when it came to sheer *stupid* stubbornness even Mydei wasn't his match. He was truly one of the kind in that sense. If he wanted to hide something then even the Gods above wouldn't make that man open his mouth. Phainon was the personification of the word stubbornness itself.

Sometimes, Mydei thought with morbid humor, *it's like that man had a personal mission to make his life as hard as it could possibly be. To push him to the end of his rope and see what made him twitch.*

(He didn't want to think of the worst-case scenario. Phainon was not the kind of person to do that.

Phainon was, Phainon was a *good* man. With iron like principles and morals.

No. Mydei wouldn't even entertain this line of thought.

It had to be something else.)

*

As soon as he started paying more attention to Phainon's whereabouts it was like the man was hellbent on proving Mydei that he was right in being concerned. As if Phainon was throwing all his excuses to the trash, unashamedly showing Mydei that *here, this is what you missed. This is what you ignored.*

Just a month ago they exchanged texts for most of the day, with Phainon sending funny cat videos and cooking tips while he was technically on the clock, and Mydei always replying with videos of what Hyacine's not-actually-so-little pet dog Little Ica has been doing that day at the bakery. But now… They exchanged maybe two or three texts throughout the day. Sometimes even less and mostly consisting of messages of when they were going home (Mydei), or to not wait for them because they were going to be late (always, *always* Phainon) – it was a far cry from their usual routine.

But the world didn't wait for them. Just as he promised, Mydei sat down and started preparing a menu for his friends' upcoming baby shower and in two weeks' time, on a nice autumn day, he met up with Cipher to discuss some details.

They just went out to take a breather, to relax after sitting in Mydei's office at the bakery for who knows how long. The weather that day was unusually warm – the wind was refreshing instead of bitingly cold, the birds were softly chirping and the trees were still clad in their golden glory, not yet naked to the human eye.

The day was perfect. It was warm, sunny – the ideal time to go out and spend time with your friends and loved ones, to enjoy your time together.

(And here is where it ended.)

Mydei was just showing Cipher a picture of the cake he wanted to bake for her and Castorice when he noticed a familiar figure out of the corner of his eye.

Phainon.

He'd recognize that white hair anywhere. He was sitting on the veranda of a café that opened recently, one that specialized in making elaborate fancy teas that neither Phainon, nor Mydei were too fond of.

What is he doing there? Didn't he say he was busy all day? Mydei thought with a frown. And then a second later, *he's wearing the gray coat I bought him recently.* Feeling satisfaction wash away all confusion, he smiled, ready to call out Phainon's name.

Things might be a little weird between them right now but he'd still take any chance to spend their time together.

But before he could even open his mouth, he saw someone join his boyfriend at the table. One was a familiar face – Cyrene, Phainon's childhood best friend. They met a few times.

Phainon introduced them as soon as they started dating, saying that *Cyrene had to be the first one to know.* Mydei wasn't sure why but it wasn't a big deal. If Phainon wanted him to meet Cyrene before meeting anyone else, that was fine with him.

Cyrene was nice, Mydei liked her a lot. Too bad she lived so far away but perhaps, with her recent promotion and possible move into the city, they will have more chances to interact.

Yes, Cyrene was fine. Great even, Mydei was happy to see her back in the city.

It was the woman next to her that gave Mydei a start. She was small, petite even, with long dark hair and a warm smile on her lips.

And based on how tight Phainon was grasping her in his arms and kissing her hair that should have been someone Mydei was supposed to know about.

Cipher was still scrolling through the folder on his phone, looking at the cake designs and sending her favorite ones to Castorice. Mydei in the meantime took a small step back, hiding in the shadow of the tree behind him. Eyes not wavering from the scene happening on the other side of the street.

Cyrene took a big sip from Phainon's cup and left soon after. Now it was just them – Phainon and the new woman. The woman who was obviously dear to him but one whose name he didn't feel like sharing with Mydei.

He saw Phainon smile at her, even pull out a chair for her, nearly falling over himself trying to act like the perfect gentleman. It was clear that whoever she was Phainon wanted to make a good impression on her.

Mydei's eyes locked on their hands intertwined on the table. The last time Phainon acted like this was during his first date with Mydei.

Who was this woman?

Mydei followed Phainon's every movement and that's why he saw the blush, the awkward laugh, the wandering eyes. The fidgeting with his phone before he offered it to the woman with a shy smile.

Number? Did he just give her his number?

Without even looking Mydei ripped his phone from Cipher's hands. Ignoring her protests, he quickly opened his chat with Phainon and typed a message. Staring down at the lone unanswered text from this morning he swallowed the lump in his throat before hitting send.

Mydei
Where are you right now? I need you to take some stuff from the dry cleaning on your way home.

He raised his head. Watched as the woman passed the phone back to Phainon with a small smirk. Saw the moment Phainon opened his message and how the smile that was on his face the whole time he was with this woman disappeared, giving way to something else.

An emotion Mydei was very familiar with.

Guilt.

Hearing a ping, Mydei slowly turned off his phone. He didn't want to know. He didn't want to open that message.

The grimace on Phainon's face spoke louder than words.

He wanted to go back to ten, fifteen minutes ago and tell past him to look away. To not turn around. Anything just so that he could continue to live in a world where everything was fine. A world where Phainon didn't lie to him for weeks on end.

Another ping.

He already knew what he would see there.

Mydei couldn't tear his eyes away from them. He saw how Phainon put down his phone, screen down, and smiled at the woman, as if apologizing that they were interrupted in such a way. He saw how they went back to laughing and talking as if that second where Mydei interrupted their time together didn't happen.

As if he didn't even exist.

A tentative hand on his arm broke the spell. Suddenly all of the street noises rushed into his ears, making him dizzy.

"Is everything alright?" Cipher looked at him with wide eyes. He must truly look like shit for her to get that look on her face.

A sardonic chuckle burst out of him, clearing through the haze. A brief moment of clarity.

"Fine," voice scrapped raw by emotion but what else can he say? There was no need to involve their friends in this.

"My apologies, I just remembered there is something I forgot to do at home. I'll send you the cake designs later. It was good to see you, Cipher."

He had to get out of there.

Ignoring her shout of his name, he strode off as quickly as he could. Away from that place, away from that café.

Just. *Away.*

He didn't run. He couldn't. Not yet. It was too soon. It would bring too much attention and that was the last thing that he wanted.

He didn't pay attention to the burning in the corner of his eyes, passing through the streets and the alleyways as swiftly as possible. Once he felt it was finally safe, his steps quickened

into a run, and he fled.

No tears fell. Not yet.

He just needed to get home. Everything would be fine once he got home.

Only there could he allow himself to break apart.

The opened messages stared at him in silent accusation.

Phainon

At the office, where else could I be?

Sorry, I can't. They will be closed by the time I'm done with work. Can you take them yourself?

*

One step into their apartment and Mydei nearly crumpled to the floor. Breathing heavily with sweat beading on his temples, he leaned against the door.

What a disgraceful image.

He quietly slid down to the floor and covered his face with his hands.

Even after seeing the proof with his own two eyes, he still refused to believe it. He still wanted to keep living in that fantasy world where everything was fine – where his parents loved him, his friends were starting a new family together and he was in love with the man of his dreams, planning their future together. He wanted that back. *He desperately wanted that world back.*

The first stone that put a crack into his perfect life was his conversation with Castorice but it was still salvageable at that point – if only Phainon hadn't lied to him.

That was the second stone. Still, they could've moved on from this.

Then Cipher.

And now… Now this.

Their words kept looping in his mind like a cursed song that wouldn't stop no matter how hard he closed his ears or how deep he buried his head into his knees.

“The one with Penacony? But didn’t they finish it almost a month ago? I think Cipher even took some days off to emotionally recover after they were finally done.”

“That’s a different contract, my dear Mydeimos. Since our original deal was so successful, Penacony decided they wanted us on more of their projects.”

“I’m the point of contact for everything related to Penacony. They can’t do anything without going through me first. There are no more deals. At least, not ones related to Penacony.”

“At the office, where else could I be? Sorry, I can’t. They will be closed by the time I’m done with work. Can you take them yourself?”

The hug, the kiss, the shy smile and the blush. He knew Phainon has always been very touchy with his friends but not like this. Never like this. That was something he used to leave only for Mydei.

Used to.

Work, office, deal, contract… Was that how an *affair* is being called nowadays?

He clamped his mouth with a sob.

The cold bed, the constant excuses…

How did he miss it?

*

It was later that night that Mydei felt Phainon crawl into bed with him, taking his usual spot at his back. Feeling a cold hand sneak under his shirt, Mydei quickly stopped it before it could settle on his chest.

He felt Phainon freeze and then move slightly so that he could see his face in the moonlight.

“You’re awake? Don’t you have an early shift tomorrow?” he whispered into the night.

Mydei replied without even turning his head. “Couldn’t sleep.”

He didn’t know what to do. He got ready to sleep on autopilot, not knowing when and if Phainon would even come home today. He never replied to his morning text, after all. Once he was in bed, he just laid awake, staring at the full moon outside of his window.

He had never felt so lost.

What was he even supposed to do now?

He felt Phainon shift once more behind him. “Hey. Look at me.”

Mydei silently turned his head.

Phainon gently cradled his face before bending down to kiss him on the forehead. “Did something happen? Why were you crying?”

Mydei’s back was still wracked with sobs when he felt something soft touch his hand.

“Mreow?” He raised his head and immediately Nikador jumped into his arms, purring and nuzzling his face. The cat was still warm – Mydei probably woke him from his nap.

“Hey,” his voice was still hoarse, as if he didn’t speak for days on end. “It’s okay, shh. I’m okay, see?” Mydei slightly spread his arms with a shaky smile. Realizing that the cat didn’t stop his nuzzling, he stopped pretending and just hugged him back. “Did I scare you? I’m sorry, I didn’t mean too.” He mumbled into the cat’s fur as if he was still a kid.

“Mreow.”

He sniffled. “You’re right. I should really get off the floor now.”

He had to get himself together. If not for himself then for Nikador’s sake.

“Just a bad day at work.” Mydei said, looking away with a blink. “Don’t worry about it.”

It was clearly the wrong thing to say because he felt Phainon’s grip around his waist tighten. “Who was it? Who made you cry?”

Stop asking. Please. Let me pretend for a little longer.

“No one made me cry, Phainon. It was just a bad day at work, that’s all.”

You! You made me cry! Why are you lying to me? How long has this been going on?

“But –” he sounded so hurt, Mydei just couldn’t do that to him. He couldn’t. Hurting Phainon *hurt him*. Even the small moment of gratification that would come with finally saying what’s on his mind wouldn’t be worth seeing the pain on Phainon’s face.

He can’t. He was a weak, *weak* man.

Mydei tried to act natural, just like he did before this… before this Penacony ‘deal’ destroyed their relationship – he plastered a smile on his face, a small one so that it didn’t end up looking like a grimace, made his eyes soften at the edges and turned around. But seeing Phainon confused face wiped any leftover fakeness from Mydei’s expression – the exasperated affection on his face was real.

“What, you’re going to fight inanimate objects now?” He smushed his cheeks like he used to do before. The skin under his palms was as smooth and as soft as he remembered.

Hearing Phainon mumble something in response, Mydei eased out on his abuse and let him talk.

He really shouldn't have because hearing Phainon's sentimental nonsense only made him want to cry more.

"I'd fight anyone and anything for you."

Mydei could only let out a wet chuckle. He would have believed it. Even a few hours ago, even with the distance that's been haunting their every interaction, even with Phainon lying and ignoring his texts - he would have believed it. There wouldn't be any need to convince him because to him that was the universal truth – he and Phainon belonged together and would do anything to stay with each other. That was how it was supposed to be.

Only now their relationship was unstable, the walls crumbling around them and Mydei didn't know how long he will be able to pretend that everything was fine.

"Mydei, what –"

"You'd tell me if something was wrong, right?" *Just tell me.*

"I… yes? Of course. But nothing is wrong. Sweetheart, are you sure you're alright?" Phainon asked, a touch of concern in his voice.

I saw you with her today. At the café. You lied to me; said you were at the office. You've been lying to me for a very long time, haven't you, Phainon?

But the words just wouldn't come out. They stuck to his throat and stayed there buried forever. A million thoughts and countless possibilities ran through his head and none of them made sense. In the end he could only choke something out, anything, as long as it got Phainon off his back.

"The last few days were… not easy, that's all."

He heard Phainon make a strangled sound at the back of his throat, his arms drawing him closer. Chest to chest now, Mydei could only stare at Phainon's sun tattoo. Anything as long as it wasn't his eyes. He didn't think he could take this right now.

He only heard a garble of his own name before he was suddenly flat on his back with Phainon on top of him, kissing every inch of his face.

Through the haze of his bewilderment, Mydei heard Phainon mumble apologies into his skin.

"I'm sorry," a kiss on the cheek. "I know I wasn't here for you," a kiss on the temple. "I missed you so much," a longer kiss on the forehead. "Mydei, you…" a breathier, more reverent than anything Mydei's every heard.

He hovered above his lips. "Let me make it up to you?"

This wasn't how it was supposed to go.

This is wrong.

Say no. End this. Do not fall for this again.

Instead of saying anything, Mydei pulled him into a rough kiss. Desperation tinged his every move. Unwilling to part for a second, not even for a breath. Anything, just to keep Phainon with him.

For all that he's called Phainon greedy in the past, Mydei himself was no better – he craved Phainon's touch, his attention, his love, everything he was willing to give him and more. Mydei wanted it all.

Maybe the best option was to let Phainon go. That's what a normal lover would have done. Let him go and watch him be happy with someone else.

But even the thought of it set Mydei's chest on fire.

Feeling hot lips trail down his neck, he thought that even if they weren't meant to be, he will still hold on until the very end. Grasping Phainon's shoulders with all the strength he had, until pale skin became red, irritated, *leaving his mark,* he knew he will not give up without a fight.

A second later Mydei felt Phainon break the kiss. He tried to pull him back, a whine unconsciously building at the back of his throat. It was too early, *he needed more.*

"Shhh, I'm not going anywhere," Phainon kissed him one more time before carefully touching his face, lifting it so that he could see what expression he was making. Instead Mydei buried deeper into his neck.

His mind grew hazy, just like it always did when Phainon kissed him. Every time he touched him, Mydei felt like all of his senses were lit on fire, fully enveloped by Phainon and Phainon alone.

"It's okay. I'll take care of you." He pressed a gentle kiss to Mydei's temple before carefully untangling them from each other.

Familiar lips trailed down, down, kissing every inch of his body, trailing his crimson tattoos with reverent lips before finally stopping at Mydei's spread legs. A nose dragged through his shorts, through the slick already pooling there. Mydei leaned on his elbows and looked down, meeting Phainon's cloudy eyes in the dark of their bedroom.

Refusing to look away, Phainon took a deep breath before his eyes rolled back and he buried deeper into Mydei's cunt, dragging the wet fabric of his shorts into his mouth.

"Gods, I missed this so much," he muttered without breaking away. Quickly he took off Mydei's sleeping shorts, nearly ripping them in the process, and finally dove in like a man possessed.

Phainon's hands gripped hard onto his thighs spreading him wide open for his own view. He spread his folds with his lips, tongue continuously pressed against his clit, teasing him with light flicks before fully enveloping it with his mouth. Mydei could only brace his hands

against their headboard and just take it because Phainon's grip did not allow him to move even a little – as soon as Mydei's hips jerked at a particularly hard suck, Phainon's grip on his thighs became even stronger. He slapped a hand over his mouth, trying and failing to stop the moans pouring from his mouth.

He screwed his eyes shut as he felt Phainon dragging his tongue from Mydei's clit to his hole, plunging inside in rapid succession. A light preview of what's to come next. Feeling a familiar heat coiling in his stomach, Mydei tried to push Phainon's head away but the infuriating man only sucked on his clit harder with an aggrieved noise.

"You... hah... are impossible," he hissed as he covered his face in embarrassment because he knew what was about to come. Based on Phainon's low moan he knew it too.

Mydei's vision blurred from the onslaught of sensations, his lips bitten red from how hard he tried to stop the desperate whines building up in his throat. He felt his whole body spasm, heat rushing between his legs. His thighs shook in Phainon's hold before he ripped them free from his hands. Clamping them around his head, Mydei rode his face with abandon, feeling every nerve in his body shake in ecstasy. He came with a cry, his mind blanking with the force of his orgasm

Strength spent, he laid on the bed, trembling. Heart pounding, every breath sent a shudder through him. But that was not enough for Phainon because before Mydei even had the chance to come back from his high, Phainon's hands once again spread his thighs and he plunged his tongue in for the second time.

Like a starved man he kept licking, sucking and *moaning*, driving Mydei into overstimulation – Mydei grabbed his head that kept moving between his legs, trying to hold onto something. His lower half shook, weak limbs trembling in Phainon's ironlike hold. Every time Mydei tried to close his legs, tried to take a breath, Phainon just dived in deeper, spread his legs even more until Mydei laid in their bed utterly spent and forced to take everything Phainon wanted to give to him. He forced himself to open his eyes, meeting Phainon's gaze, heavy and burning blue.

"Wait… I can't," he cried out, voice hoarse. "Ph-Phainon!"

He felt the pressure in his groin build, every stroke of Phainon's tongue pushing him further and further, leaving him shaking in his arms. His bones were on fire, his insides a pure, liquid heat. Every nerve singing a tune only Phainon could understand. His eyes rolled back, mouth open around the shape of Phainon's name.

Back arching, he finally felt the pressure break.

Wetness spurted right into Phainon's flushed face, drenching his face and chest in Mydei's juices. Instantly making a mess out of him.

Served him right, Mydei thought in a daze.

Still shaking from the intensity of his orgasm, Mydei, weak as a kitten, grabbed Phainon by the hair and finally pried him off his cunt. Looking at his satisfied smile, Mydei could see

that the white-haired man clearly didn't care about his whole face and neck being drenched.

Mydei let his hair go with a groan. "You're so disgusting."

Freed at last, Phainon immediately went back to his place between Mydei's legs. Laying his head on Mydei's crotch he breathed in his smell again. "Nothing disgusting about this." He pressed a soft kiss to his hipbone. "I love everything about you – how is that wrong?"

Heart constricting in his chest, Mydei carded a gentle hand through white locks, trying to smooth out what he himself ruined just a few minutes ago. He felt Phainon leave another lingering kiss on his trembling hip.

Silence blanketed the room. And for a second Mydei could pretend that everything was fine. That there were no lies, that the past weeks haven't happened and everything was still okay.

That Mydei still lived in a world where Phainon loved him.

Then Phainon opened his mouth, plunging him back into cold reality.

"How are you feeling?" His voice was uncharacteristically quiet.

"Better." *Like you still love me,* remained stuck in his throat. He swallowed and untangled another knot in Phainon's hair before moving his hands to gently cradle his face. Tugging him, he kissed him once, twice, overwhelmed with affection he felt for this man. Last kiss, lingering. He didn't want this to end. "Are you going to stop here?"

Even if you don't love me anymore… I can still give you this.

Mydei dragged his hand down, from Phainon's neck to his chest and then along the hard ridges of his stomach. He circled the dripping tip of his cock with his finger, feeling Phainon's hips twitch, dragging his hard cock between his folds.

"You…"

Mydei raised an eyebrow. A challenge. Just like before. *What, you scared?*

And when Phainon rose to the challenge just as Mydei knew he would, he grinned into the kiss, meeting him step by step.

They tore into each other, as if those months of solitude didn't exist. Mydei dug his nails into Phainon's back, left bites and bruises on his neck – anything, just to leave his mark. As if to remind the whole world, remind himself, remind *Phainon* that he was still here. *He was still here.*

Feeling Phainon finally enter him, for the first time in *weeks*, punching moans out of him with every hard thrust, he felt tears gather at the corners of his eyes. Blinking hard, he let them slide down his cheeks. *These tears are fine,* he thought almost burning with the love that surged inside of him. *Let Phainon see them. These are tears of happiness.*

He allowed Phainon to manhandle him into different positions, to bend him however he wanted, to fuck him until he was incoherent from pleasure, until dawn slowly crept across their bedroom floor. Only then Mydei smiled into his pillow, delirious but finally, *finally* feeling that ugly, festering wound inside his chest close.

At least there was still some use of him.

*

After Phainon fell asleep, Mydei quietly left the bed. He still couldn't sleep and what was the point – he had an early shift. He would leave in less than two hours anyway.

Closing the door to their bathroom, he turned the lights on and nearly jumped out of his skin when he saw his face in the mirror. Just blotchy didn't cover it. His hair was a mess and with his puffy eyes and red nose he looked exactly like he felt – like shit.

He grabbed the comb with a sigh. It seemed like he would have to stay in the bathroom until he at least looked somewhat presentable. Looking at the bags under his eyes, he thought that perhaps it was time to try that cream Hyacine was raving about at work. He was willing to try anything, as long as it made him look like an actual human and not like someone who survived a zombie apocalypse by the skin of his teeth.

It was when he started to swiftly work through his strawberry blond locks that he noticed Phainon's yesterday shirt in the laundry basket. He eyed it with mixed feelings.

Even after everything that happened, even after that scene at the cafe he still couldn't fully get rid of that persisting feeling that maybe he really jumped to conclusions. Maybe he was wrong. Maybe Phainon really didn't do anything, didn't cheat on him and all this was just a giant misunderstanding.

It ate away at his sanity. He knew if he didn't check everything, the what-ifs would haunt him forever.

He reached out for the shirt before he forced himself to stop. His fingers twitched. Did he really want to do it? Go so low as to check the laundry, searching for signs that his boyfriend was cheating on him?

The sheer idea of not trusting his boyfriend always made him scoff in the past.

If you can't even trust your supposed partner, then what is the point of staying together? He remembered himself saying as if it was yesterday. The corners of his mouth twitched. Well, would you look at him now. Someone above must be dying from laughter.

If only Phainon didn't lie to him over and over again, making it impossible for Mydei to know the truth… If only the current distance between them didn't exist. Maybe then it wouldn't have come to this.

Making up his mind, Mydei snatched the offending shirt before bringing it close to his noise and taking a deep breath.

Immediately after, under the warm light of the bathroom, his back started shaking from barely suppressed laughter. He closed his mouth with one hand. Still shaking he buried his face in Phainon's shirt and closed his eyes.

There was a trace of unfamiliar scent clinging to the piece of clothing.

Cinnamon.

Mydei hated cinnamon.

*

When Hephaestion opened the door, he took one look at his face and let him in without a word. The man was smart – he knew when to pick his battles.

In the calm of his best friend's kitchen Mydei sat at the dining table and stared at it in a daze. Out of the corner of his eye he saw Hephaestion blink owlishly at him for a bit before making himself busy at the kitchen counter.

Then there was the whistling of the kettle, as they both waited for the water to boil. Hephaestion took out two mugs from the cupboard and yawned into the crook of his elbow – Mydei must have woken him from his sleep.

In his hurry to escape from his own home he accidentally forgot that he had a key to Hephaestion's apartment. He will need to apologize for this later.

His friend put a cup of steaming hot tea in front of him with a click. It was Mydei's favorite blend with a dash of honey. Mydei quietly wrapped his hands around it, trying to warm up from the chill of the street.

"Thank you." Mydei grimaced at the hoarseness of his own voice. He took a small sip and sweetness burst on his tongue – Hephaestion made it extra sweet, just as Mydei liked it.

His friend didn't say anything and just sat down on the other chair with a frown.

"Are you okay?"

Mydei didn't want to involve other people in this but… He didn't know what to do. Constant stress, anxiety and now a sleepless night took its toll. He was overwhelmed. And when he was overwhelmed, he always went to Hephaestion.

He simply didn't know what to do.

Memories from last night kept flashing through his head. Phainon had pinned him to the bed and fucked him until he was drooling into his pillow, stuffed him so full Mydei couldn't tell where he ended and Phainon began. It almost felt like for the first time in *months*, they finally saw each other. As if no one outside of their bedroom existed – it was just them. Phainon and Mydei. Mydei and Phainon. No one else mattered.

"I love you." Phainon's lips were hot against his temple, his hips not stopping even for a second. "So much."

"Love you too," Mydei mumbled, ignoring the way his eyes burned. Ignoring the doubt creeping into his heart.

He buried deeper into Phainon's arms, breathing in his scent. Wrapping his arms and legs around him as if that might stop his boyfriend from ever leaving him.

"Mydeimos?" Hephaestion's voice broke through his memories. Mydei lifted his eyes from the table and looked at him.

The words that kept getting stuck in his throat finally slipped from his lips.

"I think Phainon is cheating on me." Mydei said evenly, staring at the shelf behind his friend's shoulder. "No. I'm sure he's cheating on me."

All he felt was overwhelming numbness. Surrounding him from every corner, freezing him in place and forcing him to watch the shitshow that have become of his relationship.

Maybe he should have known better. Maybe he should have expected something like this to happen – Mydei wasn't soft or dainty, nor was he gentle or soft. He was all hard lines and sharp edges, straightforward, prim, even rigid in some ways. Phainon was his opposite in almost every way and perhaps that's why they lasted as long as they did. Opposites attract as some may say.

It still didn't make their eventual clash any easier to bear.

Hephaestion's voice once again brought him back to reality. He asked in confusion. "Are you serious right now?"

The corners of his mouth twitched. "Do I look like I'm joking?"

"No, I mean…" He furrowed his brows. "That's impossible. Phainon would never do that."

Mydei kept staring at the shelf behind Hephaestion. "Yes, I thought so too. But I know what I saw."

But his friend kept arguing. "No, that's – Phainon would *never* do that, Mydeimos. The man is obsessed with you."

Mydei lowered his eyes back to his cup. The tea was getting cold already.

"Clearly that was a lie."

“No. No, it wasn’t.” Hephaestion shook his head. “Come on, now – Phainon was following you around since high school. You never really paid attention but I was there and I actually noticed the way he looked at you. Then you met in university again and even then, the way he looked at you never changed. That’s not something you could fake. And Phainon, for all his talents, has never been a great actor.” He thought for a second before adding, “Not when it came to you, at least.”

“Why are you defending him? You two don’t even like each other.” Mydei asked quietly.

The relationship between Hephaestion and Phainon was always rocky. Phainon got along really well with all of Mydei’s friends but Hephaestion was somehow the exception to this. Maybe it was the fact that at some point everyone in their lives expected them to become a thing – Mydei remembered Leonnius even joining some betting pools to scam people out of their money – and Phainon must have heard a fair share of these rumors back in the day.

Mydei knew that he was surprised when he learned that Mydei and Hephaestion never seriously considered dating each other. Sure, there might have been a stray thought here and there (it was bound to happen with the constant comments on their love life) but they just didn’t love each other like that. They were simply best friends, inseparable since childhood. Nothing more and nothing less.

Maybe Phainon simply didn’t like Hephaestion. Who even knew what was going on in his head. Certainly it wasn’t Mydei, as it became apparent in the last few months.

“Okay, that’s not true,” Hephaestion tried before he saw Mydei’s dead eyed stare. He tried again. “My feelings are irrelevant here – even though I’m pretty sure it’s impossible to actually hate that man, you have to be some kinda evil overlord to hate someone like Phainon – but I’m not defending him. I just…” He ran his hands through his hair, clearly stressed. “I just can’t see it. That thought would never even cross his mind. Are you sure – ”

Mydei tried to stay calm, to be patient but he could not listen to any more of this. “He *lied* to me, Hephaestion. *For months.* He was never home, always had an excuse ready on his lips when I asked him where he was and then I caught him at the park holding hands with a woman he never told me about! And he told me about all of his friends, even ones from his middle school that he lost contact with!”

Tears were brimming in his eyes once more. He grimaced, trying to get his wild emotions under control.

Hephaestion always made him show the ugliest parts of himself.

“Every time I asked him for the truth, he never gave me an actual answer, he always *lied. And trust me, I asked.*”

“And then this morning I…” Mydei bit the inside of his cheek. Swallowing hard, he continued. “I saw his shirt in the laundry basket and it…”

It was only after he put the shirt back in the basket that Mydei noticed a weird stain on its collar. Thinking the cream he just used might have left a mark, he tried to turn it the other

way just in case Phainon decided to check the dirty laundry today for some reason. He didn't want him to think he was snooping (even though that's exactly what he was doing).

Only when he picked up the shirt again, he realized that this was not a fresh stain, no. That was…

"It was a lipstick stain, Hephaestion." He shot his friend an ugly smile. "And I've never wore a lipstick in my entire damn life."

Hephaestion finally stopped his pacing. His lost expression made Mydei feel some twisted sort of relief because *finally, someone else understood what he was feeling.*

He pressed his palms to his eyes with a soft curse. "Sorry. I didn't mean to shout."

Gods, his head was killing him.

"Don't apologize. It's okay. What… what are you planning on doing now?" Hephaestion asked hesitantly.

Mydei shrugged. "Don't know. Called in sick today. Didn't want to scare Hyacine with my appearance."

He really didn't want to go home either. Everything there reminded him of Phainon.

A beat of silence. "Well, you do look like shit."

Mydei just snorted in response.

With a soft noise Hephaestion stood up and gently pried Mydei's palms from his eyes. "Stop this, you're going to make it worse." He grabbed a pill from the kitchen cabinet and slid it to him. "Here, for your headache."

Of course, Hephaestion knew about his headache without Mydei even mentioning it. He quietly took the pill. "Thank you."

His friend just waved him off. "You can stay with me today," and before Mydei could say anything, he opened his chat with Krateros and waved his phone in his face. "Already got a day off. Special privileges."

"You really shouldn't have – "

"Stop. There is no need for useless courtesy between us." He tugged on Mydei's arms and lifted him from the chair. "Come on. There is a much comfier couch in the living room. And you need to sleep. We'll talk later."

Mydei didn't protest when familiar hands settled over his shoulders, giving him an encouraging squeeze. Instinctively, he found himself leaning into his best friend's half embrace.

Yes, a couch sounded really nice right now.

*

Mydei woke up a few hours later. Still on Hephaestion's couch but now with 10 missed calls from Phainon and with his friend hovering over him with panic written all over his face.

"What… What's going on?" Still sleepy he squinted at Hephaestion in confusion.

"Phainon found out you called in sick. Don't even ask how – I have no idea." He shrugged helplessly.

Mydei just grabbed his phone from the floor when his screen lighted up once more – Phainon was calling again. Mydei exchanged a look with Hephaestion before taking the call.

Immediately Phainon's relieved voice reverberated through the microphone. "Finally! Are you okay? Why weren't you picking up?"

"I'm okay," Mydei responded with a yawn. "Just feeling under the weather, nothing serious. I was sleeping, didn't hear your calls."

"Are you with Hephaestion right now?"

"Yes." He looked at his friend who was sitting on the floor and listening to their conversation. He raised his brows. "How do you know?"

Something crashed on Phainon's end. Mydei heard him curse under his breath and couldn't help but ask, "Is everything alright? If you're busy we can talk later."

"No! No, I'm fine! Great actually! Hold on, just a second…" He heard some muffled noises as if Phainon was holding a phone to his chest. "Alright, good enough. Sorry, just a very hectic day at work."

Mydei grimaced. Work. Of course.

"How are you feeling? Do you need me to pick you up after work?"

"No. Hephaestion will take me home."

"Are you sure, I can –" Phainon said before falling silent. Suddenly he sounded angry. "Are you serious? I asked for *five minutes*, it hasn't even been two!"

Mydei widened his eyes with a start. Who was Phainon talking to?

"No, you can. Let me finish my phone call in peace and then I will join you in the meeting room. I think you can manage without me for a couple of minutes!"

"Go!"

Silence. Then Mydei heard a muffled ‘fuck’ on the other end of the phone.

Mydei frowned. “Is everything okay? I told you we can talk later. Surely, this conversation can wait?”

If Phainon was so busy then why was he so adamant on talking right now? They will see each other at home soon enough. There was no need for this.

“No. No, it can’t wait.” Phainon said firmly. “Listen, I know I’ve been… distant lately. I’m rarely at home, always busy with work and it’s just,” he breathed out, agitated. Mydei could imagine him running his hands through his hair. “A big mess. I wanted to check on you and now I can’t even talk to you because I keep getting *interrupted! Now what?!”*

Someone must have called for him again.

“Phainon…”

“No, listen.” He breathed out shakily. Mydei heard him mumble something under his breath before he spoke clearly once more. “Listen, just don’t make any plans this weekend, aright? I wanted to have a talk with you about something and it’s,” he laughed nervously, “it’s pretty important.”

A talk?... Mydei’s fingers clenched tightly around the phone.

As if feeling his apprehension, Phainon added in a hurry. “Nothing bad, I promise! Just… Make sure you’re free, okay? I’ll explain everything later. Okay, gotta run now. Bye, I love you!”

“Love you too…” Mydei looked at his phone, conflicted. Phainon already hung up.

What did he want to talk about? He didn’t want to think about the worst-case scenarios but… what if?

Mydei scowled. He really hated feeling like this. Why couldn’t Phainon just tell him the truth? What was the point of all this?

“Based on your scowl I guess you didn’t get any good news?”

He slapped Hephaestion’s hand away. “Stop poking me. And no. No good news. He wants ‘to talk’. Didn’t say about what.”

“When?”

“This weekend.”

Hephaestion whistled slowly. “Your man moves fast.”

Mydei looked at him weirdly. “What does that mean?”

His friend only shook his head, refusing to say anything.

Whatever, if it was anything important Hephaestion would have told him.

It was at that moment that his stomach decided to remind Mydei that he hasn't had anything to eat since his yesterday meeting with Cipher. He and Hephaestion looked at each other.

"I can cook – " Hephaestion started.

"I maybe be going through a relationship drama straight out of a cheap romance movie right now but I'm not yet so out of it as if to let you get anywhere near a stove while I'm here. Go make yourself busy somewhere else, lunch is on me."

"You know, my cooking actually got better lately…"

"How much better? Last I heard you put salt in your cake."

"Excuse me? Peucesta is a dirty, two-faced liar! He promised not to tell anyone!"

Mydei gave him a considering side eye. Should he tell him that everyone knows about it? No, better not. He got up from the couch and added as an afterthought, "Also, it wasn't Peucesta. It was Leonnius."

At this Hephaestion rolled his eyes with a sigh. "Of course it was that asshole. Should have expected it."

*

"Where are we going?"

"Wouldn't you like to know," Phainon shot him a strained smile before turning back to the road. His hands flexed against the wheel. Mydei quietly watched him from the passenger seat before turning back to the window.

The atmosphere in the car was not awkward but more so… heavy. As soon as they got in Phainon didn't even try to keep the conversation going, instead turning the radio on and letting some random songs break the oppressive tension in the car.

The calm before the storm. Mydei pressed his hand against his forehead as if to quell an ache with a sigh.

"Something wrong?"

Mydei shook his head. "Nothing. Just tired." He mumbled.

"Didn't sleep well?"

Mydei closed his eyes and only hummed in response.

Their phone call was only yesterday. Mydei stayed with Hephaestion for a night and in the morning his friend brought him home, just as he promised.

"Wait," Hephaestion's hand stopped him before he could open the car door. Mydei turned with furrowed brows.

Hephaestion shot a look at Phainon standing just a few steps away from his car and said quietly, "If anything happens… You know you can always come to me, right? My doors are always opened to you."

Mydei's expression softened. He gave his friend's hand a squeeze and sent him a small smile. "I know. Thank you, Hephaestion."

That was two hours ago. They've been driving for a little over an hour now.

"Hey," Mydei just opened the door, when Phainon was already waiting for him with his hand outstretched, helping him get out of the car. As soon as Mydei was out, Phainon framed his face with his hands and looked him in the eye; his hands were ice cold.

"How are you feeling? Are you okay?"

Mydei made a noise at the back of his throat, "How long have you been… Your hands – "

"Answer the question." So stubborn.

"I feel better. Nothing to worry about." Mydei scowled and quickly took Phainon's hands into his own, shoving them into his pockets to warm up. "How long have you been standing out there? You're freezing."

Phainon only shook his head with a smile. "It's okay." He then turned to Hephaestion as if remembering that he was still there. "Right. Thank you for taking care of him and bringing him back home." He took one of his hands from Mydei's grip and wrapped it around his waist, pressing him closer to his side. "If you need anything…"

Hephaestion just waved him off with an eye roll. "Wasn't a problem." He and Phainon exchanged a look. They held eye contact for a few seconds before Phainon clenched his jaw and looked away first. Hephaestion scoffed and turned to Mydei, "Call me if you need anything."

And then he was off, leaving them alone.

"Here, some hot chocolate for you."

Mydei opened his eyes with a yawn. A warm blanket fell off him. Did he fall asleep?

He took the offered cup and rubbed his eyes. "Thank you. How long was I asleep?"

Phainon took a bite of his sandwich. "Not that long? Around forty minutes, give or take." He looked at his phone that showed how long they had until they reached their destination.

“We’re almost there anyway. Thought you’d want to eat something before we got there.” He handed Mydei another sandwich with a smile.

Mydei took it and quietly thanked him. He unwrapped his food, taking a bite – Phainon got his favorites again. He looked down with a frown.

“How are you feeling?”

“Better,” he didn’t raise his eyes to look at his boyfriend and just scowled more into his sandwich. He wasn’t lying. The day he spent with Hephaestion was good for him – he did actually feel more relaxed, as if talking to his friend helped him regain some of his lost balance. Now he felt as if he was ready to face whatever it was that Phainon wanted to talk about.

Mydei pursed his lips. He hated being treated like he was fragile but he didn’t know what to do with all the conflicting information he had on his hands. One day Phainon was lying to him every chance he got and then another day he was so gentle, so thoughtful that Mydei didn’t know what to do with himself and just felt like shit for even entertaining the thought that Phainon might be cheating on him.

He took another bite.

“Did that sandwich personally offend you somehow?”

Mydei scoffed. “No, I just…” He swallowed and tried to relax his face. “I hate feeling like this.” He waved his hand as if it explained everything and wrapped his jacket tighter around himself.

Mydei saw Phainon nod from the corner of his eyes and then turn the heat up in the car. Reaching out, he tugged Mydei’s blanket up to his shoulders, covering him more thoroughly. Mydei felt like he was swaddled as a baby and scowled once more.

Seeing his frown, Phainon chuckled. “Don’t worry,” he freed one of Mydei’s hands from the cocoon he just made and pressed a lingering kiss at the back of his hand. “I’ll take care of you. I promise.”

This is not helping. Mydei looked away with a blush high on his cheeks.

His fingers twitched.

The touch burned.

*

Phainon didn’t lie – they got to their destination ten minutes after their impromptu lunch break.

For a middle of November, the weather was still considered relatively nice. The wind was cold but the sun was still shining brightly, illuminating their surroundings with its brilliant light. The leaves only started to fall, not yet withered, still retaining their warm yellow colors.

Mydei left the car while Phainon was busy taking something from the backseat. He looked around, hearing leaves crunch softly under his boots.

Why was this place so familiar?

"All done," Phainon came to his side, his soft blue eyes crinkling at the edges. With his cheeks already flushed from the cold and windswept hair he looked like someone that came straight out of Mydei's dreams.

Mydei took a warm scarf that he left at the back of the car and quickly wrapped it around Phainon's neck, looking at him with a frown. "Where are your gloves? You're going to get sick if you continue to dress this way."

"Won't you be there to take care of me anyway?" Phainon watched his hands work and smiled cheekily.

What nonsense. Of course he's going to be there. But Mydei stayed silent, only tightening the scarf around his neck in warning.

Once he deemed that Phainon was dressed warmly enough for the weather, only then did he let him go.

Even if Phainon wanted to break up… If he really fell out of love and was ready to move on to someone else, if that woman Mydei saw him with a few days ago, was that special someone for him, then Mydei… Mydei would probably have to let him go.

But he won't be the one starting this conversation. He can't. This, Phainon would have to do on his own.

He should probably feel some shame, Mydei thought absentmindedly, smoothing out the creases on his boyfriend's jacket. *Because he was not going to make it easy for Phainon.*

Anything to stay by his side.

Phainon slowly wrapped his hands around his waist and carefully nudged his face with his nose. "Hey. You really okay?"

Mydei tightened his grip on his jacket and didn't reply. Only when Phainon nudged him again did he raise his head and meet his eyes.

It's been almost five years since they got together and Phainon has not changed a bit since the time he came into Mydei's life – same fluffy hair, same always smiling mouth, same blue eyes that retained their childlike innocence.

Even though he should know better – after everything that happened, after those lonely months of constant lies, after seeing the proof with his own eyes – Mydei's heart still skipped

a beat, just like it did all those years ago.

He loved this man so much. He didn't want to let go.

"Yeah," voice hoarse but resolute. Maybe there was still a chance. He kissed Phainon's chin and, feeling coarse hairs tickling his lips, he asked with an amused smile, "Did you forget to shave today?"

Phainon looked at him with a smirk and lowered his head just so he could rub his stubble against his neck. He knew Mydei was ticklish, so he grabbed his waist tighter to make sure he stayed in one place. Feeling him rub his chin against his sensitive neck, an unrestrained laughter burst out of Mydei.

In the cold of the autumn all he felt was warmth – warmth around his shoulders, warmth around his waist, warmth in his chest. Even the coldest of winds couldn't make the fire in his body die out.

With tears forming in the corners of his eyes, he pushed Phainon's face away.

"What is wrong with you?!" he asked, his whole body still shaking from giggles.

Phainon brought him back into his arms and just smiled into his hair. Feeling Mydei start to calm down, he lifted his face from his neck and pecked him on the nose. "It's just been a long time since I heard you laugh," kissed one corner of the eye, then another. "You always looked better with a smile on your face," before finally catching his lips with his own.

The kiss was saccharine sweet. So gentle, so soft that it nearly brought tears to Mydei's eyes again. Feeling his chest constrict, he wrapped his arms around Phainon's shoulders and deepened the kiss. Breaking the kiss from time to time to giggle into each other's mouths, they continued kissing under the cold November sun.

Phainon smelled like early spring, warm but refreshing with woodsy notes deepening his scent. He was all sunshine smile and gentle laughter, skylike eyes and all enveloping warmth. Mydei stepped even closer, trying to bury into his scent, into his very being.

Even after all this time Phainon still smelled like home.

*

"Where exactly are you dragging me?"

"Come on, it won't be a surprise if I tell you! Just be patient," Phainon turned to shoot him a quick smile and continued pulling him somewhere.

The place Phainon took him to was a residential area outside of the city and since it was still an early Saturday morning, the streets were pretty empty. Mydei pushed a pile of leaves with

his boot and looked around once more. Seeing a familiar playground he stopped dead in his tracks.

“Phainon?”

His boyfriend kept pulling towards the playground. “Phainon, what – ”

“Shhh, I will explain everything once we get there.” He grinned at him, “What happened to your famous patience?”

“Don’t ‘shhh’ me, you ass. My patience is nonexistent anymore, no thanks to you.” Mydei scowled. *What were they doing here?*

Now that Mydei recognized the playground the distant memories flashed in his head. Shallow, mist like but filled with happy and bright emotions of a child – this was the place where Mydei was born and spent the early years of his childhood.

Mydei broke away from Phainon and went to the playground on his own. It was renovated a few times but the core elements remained – this little pink house used to be the ‘base’ that he and Hephaestion had when they played in their secret spies games; the horse spring rider was painted in a different color but Mydei could vividly remember little Hephaestion, wooden sword in hand, screaming righteously to Mydei *‘the evil witch will be defeated!’*.

Mydei looked at the house that was on the opposite side of the street. Seems like ‘the evil witch’ still lived there. *Not defeated then,* he thought with a smirk.

His and Hephaestion’s families moved before they went to the middle school in the area and so it took some time for Mydei to remember the place but now that he did, he turned to Phainon with a confused tilt of his head. “So, what are we doing here?”

Phainon, who watched him reminisce from the sidelines, finally decided to join him. He pointed at something on the other side of the playground. “See that swing?”

Mydei turned and saw the old thing. Out of all things on the playground that swing was the only one that wasn’t renovated for some reason. Or maybe the paint already got rubbed off. After all, the kids did like the swing. Mydei remembered the near bloodbaths that happened because of that swing alone.

“Yes? What about it?”

Phainon hugged him from behind and put his head on Mydei’s shoulder. Still looking at the swing, he left a light kiss under his jaw. “This is where I first saw you.”

Mydei turned his head to look at him. *What?*

“Huh?”

‘Yeah,” he felt Phainon smile on his neck. “I never mentioned it because technically we never spoke to each other but I also lived in the area. See that house?” He pointed at the house where ‘evil witch’ lived. “This was where Cyrene’s grandmother lives. Because of their jobs

my parents were always on the go and couldn't take me with them, so they left me with old Iris a lot of the time. I even went to the middle school here because of that."

The evil witch is Cyrene's grandmother?!

Seeing Mydei's startled face Phainon snickered. "Yes, old Iris knew all about your and Hephaestion little game. She found it very amusing. Even played into it a couple of times. Remember the haunted pumpkins and bloodsucking bats?"

"Oh god," Mydei covered his face with his hands. He will need to apologize to Cyrene's grandmother later. *This was humiliating.*

He felt Phainon's whole body shake in laughter. "Stop laughing!" he tried to elbow him in the side but the man only tightened his hands around Mydei's waist.

"It's really not a big deal," he said through another bout of laughter. "They both thought it was very sweet."

"Cyrene knows too?!"

"The bats were actually her idea. She thought it was very funny."

"I had nightmares about those bats for *years*," Mydei deadpanned. "There was nothing funny about them. Their eyes were glowing red!"

Phainon looked at him with amusement dancing in his eyes. "You remember even that?"

"They… made an impression." He was not going to admit to *anything.*

"Hold on, is that why Hephaestion still hates everything that has bats design on it?"

Mydei stayed silent. He wasn't about to snitch on his friend but yes. That was exactly why.

Phainon snickered. His silence was louder than words.

Mydei freed his arm and finally elbowed him in his side. Hearing a wheeze, he smiled. *Worth it.*

"So, what was it about you first seeing me on that swing? What does this have to do with anything?" Mydei brought them back to their original topic.

Phainon finally stopped wheezing in his ear – Mydei rolled his eyes, *the jab wasn't even that strong. So dramatic.* – before replying. "Right. What I meant to say, is that high school wasn't the first time I saw you. It was right here," he pointed at the swing. "I was sick at the time, not allowed to leave the house, so I spent all of that time reading books and playing games."

"I still remember the day I saw you here," at that point Mydei fully turned his head and looked at Phainon. His eyes were glazed over as if he was remembering something from a distant past.

“It was very cloudy that day. I think it was autumn?” he stopped for a moment and then nodded to himself. “Yes, it was pretty cold then – you were wearing your blue puffer jacket and a cute bunny hat. By the way,” he shot Mydei a quick look, “I always wanted to ask who gave it to you?”

Mydei tried to remember what he was talking about. Bunny hat… There was only one person who loved gifting him everything with bunny designs on it. “Must be from aunt Nysa.” Seeing Phainon’s questioning look, he elaborated. “Hephaestion’s mom. Remember the picture my dad sent us recently? Aunt Nysa is the one with light pink hair. Hephaestion looks a lot like her.”

“Mn, a good woman,” Phainon nodded. “That bunny hat looked criminally cute on you. Even if you kept constantly pouting,” he pinched his cheek. “Just like you do now.”

Mydei slapped his hand away. Phainon pouted. “Rude.”

“Get to the point.”

They were standing on that playground for less than half an hour and already people around them started to slowly wake up. Mydei saw the lights turn on in the house where Cyrene’s grandmother lived. He made a note in his mind to pay her a visit later.

He felt Phainon stir behind him. “Getting there. Maybe it was the bunny hat, maybe it was the fact that I was sick and didn’t know what to do with myself but since that time I first saw you on the swing, I kind of… kept watching you. It wasn’t anything weird!” He immediately defended himself when he saw Mydei’s look.

Mydei tilted his head. He didn’t think there was anything weird about this but okay.

“I just,” Phainon laughed to himself, “was very curious about you. I always saw you playing with Hephaestion and wanted to introduce myself but believe it or not, I was a pretty shy child,” he smiled at Mydei’s raised brows. “Yeah, my only close friend back then was Cyrene. It was only later that I met my other friends and got out of my shell. You were younger than me by two years, even if I didn’t know it at that time, but you were so… Intense. Everyone wanted to be friends with you,” he winked, “you were the coolest kid on the block.”

Mydei scoffed. “We were all kids, why did it even matter?”

But Phainon shook his head. “No, Mydei, you were just so… intimidating, is probably not the right word to describe a seven-year-old but that’s exactly what you were like. You were a natural leader and the kids always listened to you. You were surprisingly mature for your age, even if all that maturity disappeared once Hephaestion was nearby.” His hands once again tightened around Mydei’s waist and he mumbled into his neck. “Gods, I think everyone was so jealous of Hephaestion for being your best friend back then.”

Mydei raised his hand and carded his fingers through Phainon’s locks. He kissed his temple. “Were you jealous too?”

"…Yeah." He burrowed closer to Mydei. "By the time I got enough courage to approach you, you moved away. I thought I'd never see you again."

Mydei pressed his cheek to Phainon's temple. "But you did. A couple of years later, in high school."

The cloudy look in Phainon's eyes disappeared as he smiled. "Yes. I was so happy to see you again, even if it was just for a few months." He chuckled self-deprecatingly. "At least, this time I actually got around to introducing myself and didn't just gawk at you from a distance."

Mydei remembered it very well. He transferred in the middle of his junior year of high school; Phainon was a senior at that point.

"Hey! You're Mydeimos, right? My name is Phainon, I'm the student council president. If you need any help – just let me know! I'll be glad to assist you with anything you need."

"This time you were the coolest kid on the block," Mydei teased with a smirk.

In all the time Mydei knew him, Phainon has always been popular, that's why it was so surprising for Mydei to hear that he used to be shy when he was a kid. Be it in high school, or university, or even now in day-to-day life – Phainon always had people around him, vying for his attention. With his sunny personality, his gentle demeanor and friendliness his popularity was a given.

After all, Mydei mused, *everyone loved to bathe in the sunlight.*

"I couldn't even use that popularity to impress you," said sunlight whined into his neck. "What was the point of it – you never asked for help! I kept following you everywhere, just in case you needed something but," he groaned louder as if he could still feel the misery Phainon of that time was going through, "you always figured everything out on your own! Then I finished high school and didn't even know how to keep contact with you. It was torture."

"What, did you want to sweep me off my feet like a knight in shining armor?" Mydei asked, terribly amused.

Phainon scrunched his nose. "And what if I did? You never gave me a chance anyway; you didn't even pay me any attention back then."

Can't argue with that.

Mydei won't pretend – he really didn't pay any special attention to Phainon when they were in high school. He was nice, very friendly but Mydei was still trying to get his footing in the new school. He had other problems on his plate and a relationship just wasn't on his mind. Then Phainon graduated and that was it.

So, he stayed silent.

"What, not even going to pretend it wasn't like this?" Phainon exclaimed.

Mydei scoffed, hiding his smile in the jacket. “What’s the point. I didn’t pay you any attention even when we met in university a few years later.”

Phainon grimaced because yes, that was true. By some incredible stroke of luck, they ended up in one university. Different majors but still, what were the chances? Amphoreus has many universities, Okhema university being its most prestigious school that has many campuses in different parts of the city, and for them to not only end up in one university but on the same campus too? It's like the universe was trying to tell them something.

Phainon hugged him tighter and finally removed his face from Mydei’s neck. Mydei immediately shivered from the cold and grabbed Phainon by the neck. “No, you stay there.”

“Yes, sir.” He lowered his head back and blew warm air on Mydei’s neck. “Felling better?”

Mydei relaxed further in his hold. Leaning more on his boyfriend, he breathed in the cold autumn air. “Yes. Much better now.”

Comfortable silence settled over them. With all this back-and-forth Mydei forgot that there was a reason Phainon dragged him here.

“Why are we really here, Phainon? Don’t tell me you brought me here just to reminisce,” he said quietly, still staring into the distance.

Phainon’s hands slid lower until they settled on Mydei’s hips. He squeezed once, twice before responding. “No. I wanted to talk to you about something. Something very important.”

Breathe out. “What is it?”

He felt Phainon’s steady breath slightly hitch against his neck. “I really didn't want it to be like this.”

Mydei stayed silent, letting him talk.

Phainon’s hands fell from his hips.

“I thought I had more time.”

He moved a few steps away. The sudden rush of cold air left Mydei shivering, a slight tremor overtaking his figure.

He forced himself to open his mouth.

“What,” Mydei began, already feeling coldness creep into his chest, “are you talking about?”

He turned to face him. Phainon was pacing, clearly nervous about something. Gold eyes watched as he buried his hands in his hair, almost as if he wanted to tear it out in frustration.

“Gods, I hate doing it like this – ”

“Do you want to get bald? Stop doing that,” burst out of Mydei. He crossed the distance between them with quick strides and took Phainon’s hand away. Immediately, a familiar, ticklish kind of warmth flooded his body. Mydei resisted the urge to shiver from it.

The effect this man had on him… better if he never knew about it.

It seemed to break the tension that settled over them.

Phainon looked at him, wide eyed. His hand hanged limply in Mydei’s hold.

“You… You know I love you, right?”

Mydei tilted his head to the side, his blonde bangs falling across his eyes. “You’re not making any sense.”

Phainon laughed, a strained but oddly honest thing.

“Trust me, it will all make sense soon.” His hand regained life and he pulled Mydei close to him, chest to chest.

Before Mydei could utter a word, Phainon pressed a quick kiss to his lips and dropped to his knees.

“What are you doing?” he asked, bewildered.

“Mydei –”

“Get up, whatever you need to tell me can be said when you’re on your own two feet,” he tried to lift him up but Phainon only shook his hand.

“No, listen – ”

“There is no need for you to be on your knees. I understand – ”

Finally, not being able to take it anymore, Phainon exclaimed. “Mydei, I’m trying to propose to you!”

Mydei fell silent. And then, in the same tone, *“you’re what?”*

Phainon, still on his knees, looked up at him with a strained smile. He took Mydei’s hand again and brought it to his lips.

“Please,” he added quietly. “Just hear me out.”

Mydei stood frozen, unable to look away from Phainon. His heart thundered in his chest. He didn’t think he could say something even if he tried.

“Hephaestion told me to just be direct with you, but I,” Phainon shot him a sad smile, “I wanted it to be a surprise.”

Hephaestion knew?

As if reading his mind, Phainon continued. “Yeah, Hephaestion knew. Your parents and Krateros knew too. That’s why it took me so long – your father…” he grimaced, “did not make it easy.”

Of course, he didn’t, Mydei thought lightheaded. *He’s always been like that.*

Mydei has been dating Phainon for almost five years and yet for as long as he remembered, his father was always against their relationship. It wasn’t even something Phainon did – he was the ever-perfect gentleman. He was naturally very charming and yet that charm seemed to work against him in this particular instance because, despite Mydei and Gorgo’s countless attempts, Eurypon really could not warm up to Phainon.

“I wanted to take my time and prepare a big surprise for you. It was supposed to be on our anniversary, just a few weeks away from now, but…” he smiled ruefully, “all my planning backfired.”

Mydei felt like he couldn’t breathe. He stood there, still as a statue, and only the slight hitch of his breath showed that he was affected.

Then, all those weeks?...

Mydei pressed his other hand against his chest, feeling his heart thump erratically under his hand. He choked down his words, trying to hear what Phainon was saying.

“Imagine my surprise when Hephaestion called me yesterday and told me that you thought I was cheating on you.”

“He *what?”*

Warm breath fanned against his hand. “Please, don’t be mad at him. I roped him into it; all he did is promise to keep it a secret.” Phainon pressed a feather light kiss on his fingers, “if you want to be mad at someone – be mad at me.”

He finally stood up.

“You – ” Mydei widened his eyes. His mind couldn’t keep up with all information Phainon just dumped on him. He couldn’t even begin to think about Phainon letting *Hephaestion* of all people onto his plan. When did all of this happen?

“The proposal can wait. I will still ask you again once I explain everything, so don’t get any ideas but,” he tugged bewildered Mydei into his arms, “this conversation is better to have face to face.”

Neither of them spoke for a few minutes. They continued to hug on the playground, slightly swaying as if dancing to a tune only they could hear.

Mydei took that precious time to calm down, enough to open his mouth and ask, “What did you want to explain?”

“Everything.” Phainon pressed Mydei’s face deeper into his neck. Perhaps he knew that Mydei needed some time to process everything and was letting him hide from the world for now.

Some people would have thought that Phainon was suspiciously calm about all of this but Mydei knew all of Phainon’s tells. His voice was firm, not wavering even for a second but his hands… they were shaking. Ice cold, trying to find purchase on Mydei’s waist, tugging on his shirt.

Mydei stilled, listening closely.

“I,” he sighed, “I knew I was acting suspicious, but… I would never cheat on you. Not in a million years.”

Phainon’s breath suddenly turned slightly ragged before he forced himself to calm down. “I don’t know if Hephaestion ever told you – I know I never did – but Mydei, I… I knew I was lost the first time I saw you when we were kids. You may not remember it, may not remember me, but I know what I felt when I first saw you on that swing.”

What?

“I was a kid then but you… I remembered you very well. I tried to search for you; thought maybe you’d go to the same school as me. But what a nine-year-old can do?” he smiled a little.

“And then by some incredible luck, I met you again, in high school. Even if it was for a few months, just seeing you in the halls made me so happy. You didn’t pay me much attention but I was always there. I didn’t want to come off as needy, so I waited for the perfect chance to swoop in and use that to get close to you.” Warm lips pressed against his temple. “Later I realized it was my mistake. I should have never waited.”

Strong arms tightened around him. Mydei felt the slight tremor of Phainon’s figure, the way he frowned and screwed his eyes shut, trying and failing to control the possessive grip he had on his waist.

“But then I finished school and I didn’t have the slightest idea of how to contact you,” Phainon’s voice was no longer firm and unwavering. Instead, it was fragile, as if he was letting Mydei onto something he never told anyone about. “I tried to find you and I even saw you a couple of times, but what was I supposed to say? Even though we talked a few times in school, you still didn’t really know me. We were essentially strangers.”

Mydei slightly raised his head at that.

The swing – the place where it all started apparently. Without him having any idea.

He stared at it for a long minute, breath catching in his throat.

Phainon’s hoarse voice brought him back from his one-sided stare down. “And then you got into the same university as I and, at that point, I thought it must be fate because what were

the chances? And yet, still," he chuckled, "I could not catch your attention."

"I tried so many things – tried to take you out to coffee, bought you gifts, was more straightforward than I ever was in high school, and yet you remained indifferent. Didn't even spare me a glance."

Mydei finally found his voice, "I never realized..."

"I know. I never held it against you."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

Phainon shrugged. "At first, I didn't want to force my company on you. I thought maybe you knew that I liked you and didn't know how to let me down gently, so you pretended to not see anything. And after we started dating… Honestly, I didn't want to freak you out."

Mydei turned his head at this and frowned at him. "What do you mean 'didn't want to freak me out'?"

"Some people would describe my actions as slightly…"

Mydei tilted his head, silently asking a question.

Phainon grimaced. "Stalkerish."

He blinked. "It's fine. I don't mind if it's you."

"You…" Phainon stopped, speechless. "Huh. Really?"

Mydei nodded. He really didn't mind. Perhaps it was weird but it worked out for them, didn't it?

Phainon's shoulders sagged with a sigh. "That's good then because I don't think I know how to be normal about you." And then added under his breath, "pretty sure that's why your dad hates me so much."

"What does my father have to do with this?"

He made a face. "He may have… noticed me a few times back then? When I was looking for you after high school."

"Oh." Mydei's mouth dropped slightly, forming a perfect *O*. "So that's what all those talks were for…"

"Have you seen a strange man around the school lately? Tall, white hair, always wears a cap?"

"Did you get any new friends? By the way, give me Hephaestion phone number, I need to ask him something."

“If you see a man hiding in the bushes – don’t go up to him! Call me and run!”

Phainon buried his face in Mydei’s hair with a groan. “Don’t tell me he actually told you to stay away from me.”

He did. More than once. Now Eurypon’s reaction to Mydei dating Phainon made much more sense.

Still, Mydei buried deeper into Phainon’s embrace, *there was no need to be so dramatic.*

“Now what?” he asked quietly.

“Now…” Phainon stroked his hair, holding him close. “Now I can ask properly.”

And then he dropped to his knees. Again.

Mydei stared, eyes wide. He knew, logically he knew what Phainon was about to ask. But still, he could feel his heart in his throat, thundering in his ears, drowning out all of the noises.

It felt like every single nerve in his body was being lit on fire. Everything else faded in the background. Only he and Phainon remained.

“I’ve been in love with since I first saw you on this very playground over 10 years ago. Loving you,” he laughed weakly, “it was the most natural thing in the world to me. I didn’t even know you and yet you captivated me. From the moment on that swing, to high school, to university and until you finally gave me a chance… until the very end, I never thought I’d ever be lucky enough to be with you.”

He reached into his pocket and pulled out a ring box. “Since the day we started dating, I’ve been planning on spending the rest of my life with you.” He opened the box, revealing a familiar ring, sitting against red velvet.

Is this?... Mydei covered his mouth with a trembling hand.

“My past, present and my future – all of it belongs to you. There cannot be anyone else. *I will not accept anyone else.* Only you.” He said firmly. And then finally, *finally,* he asked.

“Mydei, will you marry me?”

Tears sprung to Mydei’s eyes, blurring his vision. The words kept echoing in his head, feeling almost surreal. Just an hour ago he thought that the love of his life was cheating on him and yet here he was – on the playground where they first met, being proposed to. He choked out a laugh.

“You…” he wiped his eyes, *“are so ridiculous.”*

Phainon laughed weakly, “That’s not an answer I’m looking for, my dear Mydeimos.”

Mydei shook his head. *How did he misunderstand something this badly?*

He didn't think of anything else. More explanations will follow but right now..

"Yes," he choked out. "The answer… the answer is *yes,* Phainon. Get the hell up and kiss me."

A brilliant, *relieved,* smile overtook Phainon's face. He immediately jumped up, bringing Mydei into a kiss.

"I love you," Mydei muttered between kisses. The tears started to slow down, yet he still felt so raw. "So, so much."

"Me too, I love you," he trailed frenzied kisses down Mydei's neck. "Love you so much…"

Suddenly he broke the kiss with a groan and leaned back. "Gods, you make me crazy. Nearly forgot the most important thing."

Mydei felt a sudden weight on his finger and both he and Phainon simultaneously lowered their heads to look.

The ring was a perfect fit.

*

"How did you even get this ring? It's a family heirloom." Mydei glanced at the ring, watching it shine in the autumn sun.

"All thanks to your mother. She helped a lot when your dad asked me to prove myself. Even Krateros gave up after a few weeks, but your father… did not want to accept it. Luckily, I'm more stubborn than he is. In the end, he had to accept defeat."

A bark of laughter. "Even my dad gave up?"

"After a while, yes," he shot Mydei a pleased grin, as he leaned against a nearby tree.

Eurypon dislike of Phainon was quite surprising considering how much he liked Phainon's parents, but Mydei's father was always a weird man. Nothing new about that.

"…Is that what you were doing all these months?"

"Yeah. I didn't think it'd take this long. They love you a lot – I thought it'd be right to get their support first."

"What if they said no? Would you have given up?" Mydei asked, curious.

"On you?" Phainon almost sounded offended. "No. Never. I'd still propose. I just… didn't want to make it hard for you. I know how much you love your family. I didn't want to make

you choose between us."

"And Hephaestion?"

"That…" Phainon scrunched his nose, "he actually found out on accident when I was visiting Krateros. I asked him to keep it all a secret."

Mydei's lips twitched. He took a fallen leaf from Phainon hair. "I imagine it was not a good day for you."

"Yeah, yeah make more fun of me, why don't you," Phainon sighed but obediently lowered his head. "Cyrene was a great help. She got me in contact with Livia again. I never knew she was a wedding planner! Saved me so much time."

Mydei froze. "Livia?"

"Yeah. We lost contact when we were kids, even before you moved away. Something about her health? She was sick a lot back then. But can you imagine, apparently Cyrene and her met again a few years later. What?" he suddenly asked. "What's that face for?"

"Do you have a picture of her?"

"Why?" but Phainon already had his phone in hand, showing Livia's contact to him. "I don't think you met her before."

And that's where he was wrong, because it took Mydei just one glance to recognize the woman on the picture.

Yeah. That was her. The woman from the park.

"No, I actually did see her once," he said slowly. If they were laying all cards in the open… There was still one question that bothered him.

Phainon sent Mydei Livia's contact and shrugged at his raised eyebrow. "You'll need to have her number too. I need you to meet her first but I'm pretty sure I want her as our wedding planner. She showed me and Cyrene some of her work and," he smiled helplessly, "it was really impressive. I had no idea you could have an ice statue at your wedding. Imagine an ice statue of Nikador. How cool is that?"

"You want an ice statue of *Nikador*? Our *cat* Nikador?"

Phainon just blinked innocently at him. "Why not? I think your dad would love it – he treats the demon cat better than he treats most people anyway." He laughed at Mydei's stunned look. "I'll send you Livia's portfolio later, see if you like anything from there." Then he frowned, as if he remembered something. "Wait, back up. When did you see Livia?"

Mydei twirled the leaf he just got out of Phainon's hair before he stared intently at his fiancé, "At the park, a few days ago."

"A few days ago," Phainon repeated slowly. "… Don't tell me you were there."

Mydei silently nodded.

“So, I didn’t make that up. Huh.”

“What are you talking about?” he asked with a frown.

“I heard Cipher calling for you but I thought my mind was just playing tricks on me,” Phainon muttered, trying to remember that day. “Cyrene told me before that she was bringing Livia and that she might be able to help me with some things but… You said you were there? Then… Oh. *Ohhh*,” he suddenly made a face. “Now it makes sense.”

“You lied,” now Mydei knew why but he still needed to hear it from Phainon.

“Yeah, not my best moment,” he said with a grimace. “How was I supposed to know you’d be there? What, was I supposed to say ‘no, I’m not at work, I’m actually meeting our possible wedding planner who also used to be my childhood friend, and yes, we are getting married, you just don’t know about it yet because your family has been tormenting me for months and I didn’t have a chance to propose’? Come on now.”

Mydei huffed because he saw Phainon’s point but “That’s not… I understand now why you didn’t say anything. It’s,” he looked up, unsure how to bring it up. Seeing Phainon’s encouraging smile, he finally asked, “there were lipstick stains on your shirt. It was on that day, right after you met Livia.”

Phainon reeled back as if struck. *“Lipstick stains?”*

Mydei didn’t trust himself to talk so he nodded again.

“I guess I was too excited when I saw her. Maybe her lipstick got smudged when I hugged her? I’m not sure, to be honest,” Phainon murmured. Mydei was just about ready to brush it off when Phainon hurriedly added, “but I swear there’s nothing between us! For once, she has a husband and also, I spent half of our meeting showing her your photos from my Mydei album! There’s just no way, I swear.”

He even put his hand to his chest for an added effect but Mydei was stuck on one thing. “’Mydei album’? What the hell is that?”

“My photo album,” Phainon blinked owlishly at him in response. “With your pics. I told you about it before, no?”

“I thought that was a joke!”

Mydei knew Phainon loved taking pics of them – the walls in their apartment were full of photos Phainon made. Their first New Years together, their first date, their first anniversary – they got everything and more. It was one of Phainon’s hobbies that not many people knew about. If he wasn’t such a good lawyer, he’d make a fantastic photographer.

Mydei always found it incredibly charming when Phainon kept taking pics of everything. He had everything divided into different colored folders and sometimes he spent hours editing the photos – he was really passionate about it. It was sweet.

Of course, Phainon showed him the photos he took and he'd heard him say that this or that photo was going into his 'Mydei album' but… He'd said it so often that Mydei assumed he was joking.

Apparently, he wasn't.

"Here," Phainon gave him his phone.

"What?"

Phainon came up to him from behind and said with a smile, "just look for yourself."

The phone was already unlocked. Mydei stared at the picture of himself and Nikador sleeping on the couch.

He forgot Phainon still had this photo set as his home screen.

"Really now," he murmured under his breath.

"What, it's a good pic."

"I have *drool* on my face."

"You always have drool on your face when you're sleeping," Phainon laid his head on Mydei's shoulder. "It's cute. Now open the gallery."

Mydei looked at him in disgust but did as he asked. Immediately he saw multiple albums – all with unique covers and titled with different names. And right there in the middle was Mydei's album.

"Why is mine pink?"

Phainon shrugged. "You love pink. It reminds me of you."

"I remind you of color pink?" Mydei turned to him, appalled.

"Yes? You love it. You even drink that one disgusting fruit tea because it's pink."

"I don't drink it because it's *pink*. It's good for your body, it has many vitamins and it's not disgusting. I'm not so superficial that I would – "

"You do remember that I was there with you when you bought that tea for the first time, right?" Phainon interrupted him, curious. "The shopkeeper just mentioned that the tea had a 'beautiful pink hue' and you bought it the next second. It was only later that we both found out that it was a fruit tea." And then he added, "I was the one who actually told you that."

Mydei turned back to the phone in his hand, ignoring his words. "The album is locked?"

Phainon snorted, amused. "Yes, want to guess the password?"

Mydei frowned. Usually, he was pretty good at guessing games (the last few months were different. He was stressed; it didn't count.) so he'd give it a shot.

He gave Phainon a quick nod.

'Mydei album', he mused. The obvious choice would try his birthday but Mydei didn't think Phainon would put it there. He'd definitely go for something more… personal.

He quickly typed the date of their first date – the album unlocked.

Heh, first try.

Mydei grinned when he heard Phainon slightly choke on air.

"I thought you'd go for our anniversary first…"

"Too obvious," Mydei shook his head. "Many people know the date of our anniversary. Only you and me know when we went on our first date."

"That is true," he tightened his hands around Mydei's waist with a sigh. He quickly pecked him on the cheek and teased, "look at you, so smart."

"Shut it," Mydei just lightly swatted him on the thigh with a huff.

He turned back to Phainon's phone and saw that this album had little subsections, each with a different title. There was 'morning Mydei', 'Mydei in the park', 'Mydei in the kitchen' and even one titled 'Mydei with his friends'. Each album had at least over a hundred photos. He clicked randomly on one and saw a picture of himself and Ptolemy, eating ice cream in an amusement park. That was from a year ago.

He clicked on another one – this time it was Mydei with his parents. He remembered this moment; it was right before his cousin's wedding from three years ago. They accidentally met each other in the mall when they were buying a gift for Lyra and her wife and decided to go shopping together. In the photo Mydei was showing Gorgo what he was planning to buy, while Eurypon was squinting at something in the background a few steps away from them.

Another picture – this time it was just Mydei. He was standing in their kitchen, with his eyes closed and still clad in his sleeping shorts, waiting for the kettle to boil. Mydei looked at the date. This one was from four days ago.

Mydei looked up at Phainon, feeling overwhelmed.

"You… Why?"

"Why not?" Phainon hugged him tighter. "I miss you sometimes. I look at these photos when you're not with me." He pressed a kiss to the side of his head, "You don't know how much this album saved me when I was dealing with your father. He was a *menace*."

"Was?" A wry smile twisted Mydei's lips.

Phainon nodded, “Yep! We have declared a truce for now. He won’t be a problem anymore.”

“Did my mother get involved?” Mydei turned in his arms, suspicious.

“Maybe,” he laughed. “She did threaten him a few times and you know what your mom is like. A ferocious woman, that’s for sure.” And then, “still don’t know why she likes me so much but I’m definitely not complaining.”

Mydei huffed. He knew why.

Gorgo was supportive of their relationship but it wasn’t always like this. She was quieter by nature, not afraid of being in the spotlight but almost never seeking it on her own. The exact opposite of her chaotic husband that brought his intensity and passion into every aspect of his life – be it love or hate.

Just like Eurypon, she must have known about Phainon long before Mydei actually started dating him and Mydei, now that he knew the whole story, had to admit, Phainon’s first impression on his parents was probably… not great.

Still, when Mydei brought his then new boyfriend to meet his parents, she, unlike Eurypon, was not as obvious with her thoughts. She was polite, friendly even, especially compared to her husband who sat there frozen stiff with anger. Phainon hadn’t realized anything back then, too focused on trying to stay polite with Eurypon glaring daggers at him, and Mydei didn’t tell him but he knew his mother – he knew she was keeping her distance. It wasn’t outright disapproval but it wasn’t approval either.

And he… He was always much closer with his mother. He loved his dad but his bond with Gorgo has always been different. They understood each other like no one else, and he knew why she was acting this way; she was much more cautious than anyone else in their family, but still, it hurt. *It hurt a lot.*

It was only a few months later that Mydei saw an actual change in how she treated Phainon. Phainon himself didn’t do anything special, he was just himself – friendly, loyal, incredibly charming, even if he sometimes acted like a besotted fool. It wasn’t noticeable to anyone else, but Mydei was always very attuned to his mother. He noticed immediately how much she warmed up to him. When he asked her, she gave him a very simple answer.

“Phainon is a good man. And he adores you.” She pressed a light kiss to his forehead. “You two suit each other well, son. That’s more than enough for me.”

And that was that. Ever since that moment, she was always supportive of their relationship. A pillar Mydei knew he could always lean on when his dad was going overboard with his cutting remarks about Phainon.

Phainon’s voice pulled him back from his memories.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” he asked with a soft smile.

Mydei blinked, realizing he’s been staring at Phainon for some time without saying a word.

The November sun clung to Phainon's skin, bathing him in its golden light. From Mydei's point of view it looked like he had a halo behind his head.

His next words slipped out almost instinctively.

"She likes you because you're a good man," Mydei said quietly, mesmerized by the brilliant man before him. "Shouldn't that be enough?"

And, Mydei watched as a bashful but radiant smile crossed Phainon's face, almost dazzling him with its light. He reached out, his hands gently cradling Phainon's face, *because you make me the happiest man in the whole world.*

As Mydei pulled him in a kiss with a smile of his own, he knew there was no telling what tomorrow might bring.

But whatever it was, he and Phainon would face it.

Together. Like always.

End Notes

took me over a month to finish but finally it's here. didnt expect to see phaidei get married on screen when i first started this fic but thank u 3.7, u will always be dear to me

there's no excuse, i really just wanted to see mydei cry. and also see phainon make out with mydei's pussy bc good lord that man #wants that

idk what im doing here bc i stopped writing like 10 years ago but ✌️ hope you liked whatever tf this was. i was thinking of making a fic with phainon's pov but theres just gonna be a stupid amount of yearning in there so im still kinda thinking about it

english isnt my first language so if u see any mistakes - assume that shit was on purpose, idc anymore 🙏

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